

Jay C. Krisell

M.S.E.E. Candidate · University of Arkansas
jckrisel@uark.edu · (501) 269-5750 · Fayetteville, AR

Letter of Interest

2026–2027 Hodges Graduate Entrepreneurial Fellows Program

April 1, 2026

Dear Hodges Graduate Entrepreneurial Fellows Selection Committee,

I am applying to the Hodges Graduate Entrepreneurial Fellows Program because I am trying to build something real, and I know I am at the point where stronger entrepreneurial training would make a real difference.

I am currently pursuing my Master of Science in Electrical Engineering at the University of Arkansas, where I work in the Cognitive Robotics Lab under Dr. Tuan Dang. My research is centered on reinforcement learning for robotic control. At the same time, I am building Kinetic Intelligence Labs, where I am developing motor control hardware and training systems for robotic actuators. The work is technical, but the goal is simple. I want to help build robotics systems that are actually capable, scalable, and practical to deploy.

A big part of why this matters to me comes from how I was raised and the kind of work I have been around. I grew up watching my father build his HVAC business from the ground up. I saw what it looked like to carry responsibility, solve problems daily, and build something that had to survive in the real world, not just look good on paper. That stayed with me. I have wanted to build something of my own for a long time. My own path has shaped that even further. I joined the Arkansas Army National Guard at seventeen and trained as a 15F Aviation Electrician. I spent six years working on helicopter avionics, and that experience changed the way I think. It taught me discipline, accountability, and how serious technical work needs to be approached when reliability actually matters. Later, as a Sergeant, I led maintenance teams and learned how to take ownership not just of the work, but of the people and standards around it.

As I moved deeper into engineering, that same mindset carried over. I completed my electrical engineering degree at the University of Arkansas and had the chance to work at Bosch in Electro-Voice R&D in Burnsville MN. That role gave me exposure to product testing, prototype electronics, and the kind of engineering judgment that comes from working around real performance constraints.

Now in graduate school, I am in a position where my research and my startup direction are beginning to converge. What I am trying to solve is a problem I keep running into in robotics. The software side is moving fast. Reinforcement learning, simulation, and motion control are getting better every year. But the hardware side still has a major gap. There are not enough actuator level control systems that are compact, affordable, and capable enough to support the kind of performance modern robotics needs. A lot of the existing options are either too expensive for scalable systems or too limited to be taken seriously in advanced applications. I want to help close that gap.

That is the reason I started Kinetic Intelligence Labs. I am in early stages of developing TITAN FOC as a custom motor controller platform built for robotic actuators, with the longer term goal of pairing it with training and deployment systems that better connect simulation to real hardware. I believe there is real commercial potential in that direction, especially if it is developed with the right discipline from the beginning.

What I need now is not more motivation. I already have that. What I need is the right structure to become stronger on the business side of what I am building. I want to learn how to approach customer discovery the right way, think more clearly about intellectual property, build a real go to market path, and understand how to make better commercialization decisions earlier. That is why this fellowship stands out to me. It would help me build the judgment and foundation I need so that I do not just create good technology, but create something that can survive, grow, and actually matter.

I believe I would bring seriousness, technical depth, and long term commitment to this program. I am not exploring entrepreneurship casually. I am pursuing it because I want to build a company around engineering work that I believe has real value. I would be grateful for the opportunity to grow through the Hodges Fellows Program and contribute to that community.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,
Jay Krisell

Jay C. Krisell

M.S.E.E. Candidate, University of Arkansas
Founder, Kinetic Intelligence Labs
jckrisel@uark.edu · (501) 269-5750